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AAE 512
Research Proposal

I. Research Question and Hypothesis

My research aims to answer: does living near Chinese-funded Belt and Road initiative (BRI) infrastructure make citizens feel more economically secure, or does it trigger fears of strategic dependence and lost sovereignty? I have two hypotheses:

> Hypothesis 1 - Proximity to visible transportation infrastructure (e.g., high-speed rail or highways) increases personal perceptions of local economic opportunity and positive views of Chinese economic engagement.
>
> Hypothesis 2 - Proximity to resource-extraction or energy projects increases anxieties regarding national sovereignty and strategic economic vulnerability.

My research will look at this question across six Southeast Asian nations (Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Vietnam, Philippines, Thailand) using Asian Barometer data and AidData's Geo dataset.

II. Motivation and Literature Review

Summary of the literature - Research on how Chinese engagement shapes public opinion has been largely centered on Africa. Blair et. al (2022) link Afrobarometer respondents to AidData project locations and compare residents near completed projects with those near planned ones. Their theory runs from exposure to attribution to ideological alignment, and they find little support for the idea that Chinese aid builds soft power. Completed projects actually diminish support for China. Related work on Sub-Saharan Africa finds that Chinese aid can worsen citizens' assessments of their government's performance (Atitianti and Asiamah 2023). In Southeast Asia, the evidence is thinner and inconclusive. Meesuwan and Park (2025) use Asian Barometer data from 2010 to 2022 and find that Thai citizens who favor concentrated executive power rate China's role more positively, so perceptions of China are filtered through domestic political values rather than shaped by aid alone. The authors also note that countries in territorial disputes with China tend to see Chinese investments as strategic intrusion. Tan and Hoang (2026) surveyed users of Chinese-built transport projects in Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos and Vietnam and find generally positive ratings of quality, convenience, and practical benefits. Although, concerns about debt, the environment, and weak oversight by Chinese construction firms persist. Hiep et. al (2025) and Albana and Fiori (2021) highlight the drawbacks of the BRI, specifically in Vietnam. Reputational damage from incomplete projects, local frustrations that benefits stay primarily within the Chinese community, worsening inequality, and that Chinese influence is seen as a threat to local culture and environments are cited examples. However, neither study measures perceptions directly.

Gaps and what this paper addresses - This paper aims to address two gaps in the current literature. First, the strongest causal evidence on local attitudes toward Chinese projects comes from Africa, where distance to China is further; it may not carry over to Southeast Asia, where proximity to China and strategic concerns could change how projects are read. Second, the existing literature is limited to one project type. We know little about whether different types of infrastructure projects shape perceptions differently. Rather than studying a single sector, this study aggregates projects across sectors, including transport, energy, and resource extraction, to estimate how proximity shapes perceived economic security and dependence and whether the effect differs by project type. Finally, this paper adapts the spatial DiD approach of Blair et al. (2022) to Southeast Asia and extends it to new outcomes (economic security and dependence). This paper addresses these gaps by linking geocoded BRI project data to Asian Barometer respondents in Southeast Asia. Treatment is defined as citizens living in close proximity to completed BRI projects, and the control group is citizens living farther away in unexposed regions.

III. Data

This project merges three high-resolution datasets across SEAsian nations (Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Vietnam, Philippines, Thailand) from 2010 to 2021:

Treatment Data (Infrastructure Projects) - AidData's Geospatial Global Chinese Development Finance Dataset (GeoGCDF V3.0). This provides vector lines (highways, railways), polygons (power plants, industrial zones), and calendar-day initiation and completion dates. Respondent locations are constructed from the sampling frames in each Asian Barometer country technical report, which list the provinces, districts, and communes where interviews took place. I geocode these locations to administrative boundaries and compute distance to completed Chinese-financed projects. Where only district-level information is available, treatment is defined at the district level

Outcome Data (Micro-Level Perceptions) - Asian Barometer Survey (ABS) from 2010 to 2021 [Waves 3, 4, and 5]. Key outcome variables include individual survey responses measuring:

- Core Topic A: The economic condition of the country and your family-now, the last 5 years, and in the next 5 years
- Core Topic M: Trust in Government
- China Index: Impressions of China, whether China does more good or harm to the region, and the influence of China

Spatial Controls: Satellite nighttime lights (*VIIRS*) and (*DMSP)* to control for baseline district-level economic growth.

IV. Empirical Strategy

To address non-random project placement, this paper uses a spatial difference-in-differences (DiD) design. Using GIS software, I draw buffer zones around each geocoded BRI project. Respondents living within 25 km of a project are the treatment group, and respondents living 100 km or more away in the same administrative region are the control group. Because projects finish at different times, I compare changes in perceptions before and after a project's completion date between the two groups.

The baseline model is:

$$Y = \alpha + \beta(\text{Treated} \times \text{Post}) + \gamma X + \delta N + \text{District FE} + \text{Time FE} + \varepsilon$$

- Y: Respondent's perception of economic security or economic dependence on China.
- Treated: 1 if the respondent lives within 25 km of a BRI project.
- Post: 1 if the survey took place after the project's completion date.
- β: The effect of interest, the change in perceptions among nearby residents after a project is completed, relative to residents farther away.
- X: Individual controls (age, education, income tier).
- N: Local nighttime light intensity, as a proxy for local economic growth.
- District and time fixed effects: Account for stable differences across districts and for shocks common to each survey period.

Effects are estimated separately by project sector (transport, energy, resource extraction) to test whether the direction of the effect differs by project type.

V. Expected Contributions

This paper contributes to the literature on foreign finance and public opinion in three ways. First, it moves beyond Africa-focused evidence by estimating how living near completed BRI projects affects perceptions of economic security and dependence among Southeast Asian residents. Second, it uses geocoded project locations and completion dates to compare respondents near and far from projects, rather than relying on country-level comparisons or surveys of project users. Third, it compares project types (transport vs. energy and resource extraction) to show whether the kind of infrastructure matters for how people interpret Chinese presence. The findings will help recipient governments and development partners understand which projects are likely to generate local support or resistance, and where concerns about dependence are strongest.